The Pivot Method: A Full Guide to Career Change

Based on "Pivot: The Only Move That Matters Is Your Next One" by Jenny Blake

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Introduction

Jenny Blake worked at Google for five years in training, coaching, and career development before pivoting to launch her own career consulting business. Her framework for career change is based on real experience and has helped thousands of professionals navigate transitions successfully.

Understanding the Pivot Framework

What is a career pivot?

Jenny Blake defines a career pivot as "doubling down on what is working to make a purposeful shift in a new, related direction."

This comes from Eric Ries' definition of a business pivot in The Lean Startup: "a change in strategy without a change in vision."

In practical terms, a pivot means you're not starting from scratch. You're leveraging your existing strengths, skills, and experience to move in a related direction. Think of it as a basketball pivot: one foot stays planted (your foundation) while the other explores new territory.

What a pivot is NOT:

- Quitting your job with no plan
- Starting over in a completely unrelated field
- Chasing a dream with zero relevant skills
- A midlife crisis or breakdown

What a pivot IS:

- An intentional, methodical process for career change

- Building on your existing strengths and experience
- Testing new directions before fully committing
- Reducing risk while exploring opportunities

The smartphone analogy

Careers used to be like ladders (linear, predictable, one path up). Now they're like smartphones (modular, customizable, dynamic).

Your education and upbringing are the out-of-the-box model. After that, it's up to you to download the apps, skills, interests, experiences, education, that you want and need.

A pivot is about downloading new apps one at a time, not trying to upgrade your entire operating system overnight.

Why pivoting matters now

The career landscape has fundamentally changed:

- Average job tenure in America: 4-5 years (down from decades)
- Average person will have 11+ jobs in their lifetime
- You'll likely change industries 3-6 times in your career
- Traditional pension plans are mostly gone
- Jobs change dramatically even within the same role

As Blake writes, "Your choice, today and in the future, is to pivot or get pivoted."

The market will force change on you eventually. Either you proactively manage your transitions, or external forces (layoffs, industry disruption, skill obsolescence) will make the decision for you.

The Five Stages of a Pivot

Pivot Method has five distinct stages: Plant, Scan, Pilot, Launch, and Lead. Each stage builds on the previous one. Most people skip straight to Launch (making the big move) without doing the foundational work, which is why so many career changes fail.

Stage 1: Plant 🌱

Purpose: Set your foundation before you move.

Plant is about getting clear on four critical areas before you start exploring new directions. This stage prevents you from making reactive, fear-based decisions.

1. Calibrate Your Compass

Your compass is your set of guiding principles and values. It helps you make decisions when you're facing uncertainty.

- What are your core values? (Not what should matter to you, but what actually does)
- What energizes you versus drains you?
- What are your non-negotiables in work and life?
- What does your ideal day look like?

From a recruiter's perspective, I see candidates who haven't calibrated their compass make terrible decisions. They take jobs for money, then quit six months later because the culture is toxic. They chase titles without considering whether the role actually uses their strengths.

Exercise:

Create your happiness formula.

What combination of factors makes you feel fulfilled at work?

For some it's autonomy + learning + impact.

For others it's stability + clear expectations + collaboration. There's no right answer, but you need to know yours.

2. Put a Pin in It

This is about creating a vision for where you want to be in one year. Not five years, not ten years. One year.

Key questions Blake recommends:

- What excites you most right now?
- What does success look like one year from now?
- Where do you want to be (role, company, industry, lifestyle)?

Important: Your vision doesn't need to be crystal clear. Blake warns against "the tyranny of the hows" getting stuck because you don't know exactly how you'll get there. You just need direction.

Recruiter reality check:

When I ask candidates "where do you see yourself in a year?" most give vague answers. The ones who get hired have specific visions: "I want to be leading a team of 5 engineers working on AI infrastructure" or "I want to be consulting 3 days a week while building my own product 2 days a week."

Specificity helps you (and others) identify opportunities.

3. Fuel Your Engine

This is the most skipped step, and it's critical. You need to identify what's already working before you can pivot.

Blake's framework asks:

- What are you naturally good at?
- Where do you excel with minimal effort?
- What do people consistently come to you for help with?
- What skills have you developed that transfer to new contexts?

Most people focus on their weaknesses or what they think they should be doing. Successful pivots leverage existing strengths in new ways.

Exercise: Do a work history highlights review. Go through your past roles and identify:

- Projects you loved and did well
- Skills that came naturally
- Moments when you felt "in flow"
- Accomplishments you're genuinely proud of

Look for patterns. Those patterns are your fuel.

From my recruiting experience: I see engineers pivot to product management (analytical thinking + user empathy), consultants pivot to internal strategy roles (problem-solving + communication), and teachers pivot to corporate training (instruction + curriculum design). They don't start from zero, they re-aim their strengths.

4. Fund Your Runway

Blake is blunt about this: you cannot pivot from a position of financial desperation.

Questions to answer:

- How long can you sustain your current lifestyle without income?
- Can you create additional income streams while employed?
- What's your absolute minimum financial safety net?
- What creative ways can you extend your runway?

Minimum recommendation: 3-6 months of expenses saved before making any major move. Ideally more if you're supporting a family or pivoting to a lower-paying field initially.

Blake suggests ways to extend runway:

- Freelancing or consulting in your current field
- Teaching or coaching on the side
- Reducing expenses temporarily
- Negotiating a part-time arrangement
- Securing clients before leaving your job

Recruiter's note on negotiation: Desperation kills your negotiating power. When I'm hiring, I can sense when a candidate needs the job versus wants the job. The ones who want it (because they have options) get better offers. Build your runway so you're negotiating from strength, not desperation.

Stage 2: Scan 🔍

Purpose: Gather intelligence before you leap.

Now that you know where you want to go (Plant), you need to figure out how to get there. Scan is about research, networking, and skill assessment.

1. Bolster Your Bench

Your "bench" is your network of advisors, mentors, and connections who can help you navigate your pivot.

- Who do you already know in your target field?
- Who can provide honest advice about the transition?
- What can you offer in return? (Career karma matters)
- Who has made a similar pivot successfully?

Most people think networking means asking for favors. Blake reframes it as building reciprocal relationships. The best networkers give first, ask later.

Practical approaches:

- Informational interviews (20-30 minutes, focused questions)
- Industry events and conferences
- Online communities in your target field
- Alumni networks from your school or company
- Second-degree connections through LinkedIn

Recruiter's truth: 70-80% of jobs are filled through networks, not job postings. Your resume matters less than who's championing you internally. When I hire at Uber, I always ask my team "who do you know?" before posting externally.

Build relationships before you need them. The time to expand your network is while you're employed and not desperate.

2. Bridge the Gaps

This is about honest skill assessment. What do you need to learn to be competitive in your new direction?

Blake suggests:

- Identifying required skills for your target role
- Assessing which ones you have versus need

- Creating a learning plan to bridge gaps
- Being strategic about what to learn first

Mind the gap: Don't assume you need to learn everything before making a move. Focus on the skills that are:

1. Most critical for the role
2. Hardest to fake or learn on the job
3. Most valued in your target market

From my experience screening resumes: I look for proof you can do the job, not proof you have every qualification listed. 60-70% match is often enough if you can tell a compelling story about the gaps.

Ways to bridge gaps:

- Online courses (Coursera, Udemy, platform-specific training)
- Certifications (especially for technical fields)
- Side projects that demonstrate skills
- Volunteer work or pro bono consulting
- Shadowing someone in your target role

Blake also warns against "linear thinking" assuming you need to take step 1, then step 2, then step 3 in sequence. Often you can leapfrog steps or learn things in parallel.

3. Make Yourself Discoverable

Visibility matters. You can have the right skills and network, but if no one knows you're looking or what you offer, opportunities won't find you.

Blake's framework for discoverability:

- Define your unique value proposition
- Build a platform (website, LinkedIn, writing, speaking)
- Do work that gets noticed
- Let your network know you're exploring

Project-based purpose: Don't wait for the perfect job title. Define yourself by the projects you're working on and the problems you solve.

Example: Instead of "I'm a marketing manager looking to pivot to product," try "I'm working on user acquisition strategies for SaaS products and helping companies optimize their onboarding funnels."

Recruiter's perspective on visibility:

When I'm hiring, I look for candidates who:

- Have an updated LinkedIn profile with specific accomplishments

- Participate in relevant communities (commenting, sharing insights)
- Have work samples or portfolios I can review
- Come recommended by someone I trust

The "spray and resume" approach (applying to 100 jobs) rarely works for career pivoters. Targeted visibility works better: be known by 10 people in your target field who can vouch for you.

Blake's leapfrog strategy: Work backward from two moves ahead. If your goal is to be a VP of Product in 5 years, what role comes before that? What role comes before that? Then position yourself for the next logical step, not the end goal.

Stage 3: Pilot 🧪

Purpose: Test before you commit.

This is Blake's most important contribution to career change methodology. Instead of making one big leap, you run small experiments to gather real-world data.

Most career change advice skips this step entirely. People quit their jobs to "pursue their dreams," then discover they hate the reality of that dream. Pilots prevent this costly mistake.

What makes a strong pilot?

1. Low risk, low cost

- Can be run while employed
- Doesn't require quitting your job
- Minimal financial investment
- Reversible if it doesn't work

2. Provides real-world data

- Tests actual interest and aptitude
- Gives you market feedback
- Validates (or invalidates) assumptions
- Answers specific questions

3. Tests one variable at a time

- Don't change everything at once
- Isolate what you're testing (role, industry, environment, skills)
- Makes results clear and actionable

Examples of strong pilots:

- Freelance project in your target industry (tests: can you do the work? do you enjoy it?)
- Side project or passion project on weekends (tests: interest, skill, market demand)

- Consulting for 1-2 clients while employed (tests: business viability, client acquisition)
- Teaching a course or workshop (tests: expertise, communication, interest in education)
- Volunteer role in new field (tests: culture, day-to-day reality, connections)
- Informational interviews with 10 people doing your target job (tests: assumptions, reality check)

Experimentation framework:

Aim for quantity first, not quality In the pilot phase, you're gathering data. Run multiple small experiments rather than one perfect test.

Example: If you're considering freelance writing:

- Pitch 10 publications (tests: market demand)
- Write 5 sample articles (tests: do you enjoy the writing process?)
- Join 2 writing communities (tests: culture fit)
- Interview 3 full-time writers (tests: reality of the career)

Questions to answer through pilots:

- Does this work energize or drain you?
- Can you realistically do this work?
- Is there market demand for your skills?
- Do you enjoy the day-to-day reality (not just the idea)?
- Can you make enough money doing this?
- Do you like the people in this field?

My recruiting lens on pilots:

When I review resumes from career pivoters, I look for proof of pilots. Someone transitioning from consulting to product management should have:

- Product side projects or case studies
- Experience working with product teams (even internally)
- Product certifications or courses
- Evidence of product thinking in their current role

Without pilots, you're asking employers to take a bigger risk on you. With pilots, you have proof of capability and genuine interest.

Pilots reduce employer risk. That's what most candidates don't understand. Companies don't reject career pivoters because they lack credentials, they reject them because there's no evidence the candidate can actually do the work or will stick with it.

Incremental pilots within organizations

Blake emphasizes you don't need to leave your company to pivot. Many successful pivots happen internally through:

- Volunteering for cross-functional projects
- Taking on stretch assignments
- Shadowing other teams
- Leading initiatives outside your core role
- Internal transfers or rotations

At Google, Blake pivoted from AdWords training to career development while still at the company. She built the foundation through side projects and internal initiatives before officially changing roles.

From my experience at Netskope: I pivoted from general recruiting to specialized cybersecurity recruiting by first taking on cybersecurity roles at my job, learning the technical landscape, building relationships with that team, and proving I could deliver. The formal role change came after I'd already demonstrated success.

Pause, review, repeat

After each pilot,:

What worked?

- What energized you?
- What feedback did you get?
- What surprised you positively?

What didn't work?

- What drained you?
- What was harder than expected?
- What disappointed you?

What's next?

- Continue this pilot?
- Try a variation?
- Run a different experiment?
- Ready to launch?

The pilot phase isn't about getting it perfect. It's about gathering evidence to make informed decisions. Some pilots will confirm your direction. Others will redirect you to something better.

If you hate the pilot, you'll hate the pivot. Better to discover this while you still have your job and income.

Stage 4: Launch 🚀

Purpose: Make the big move when you're ready.

Launch is not about courage. Blake's key insight: "Build first, courage second."

Most people think they need to gather courage before making a move. Blake flips this: you need to build evidence, skills, and runway first. When you've done the work in Plant, Scan, and Pilot, the launch becomes less scary because it's data-driven, not fear-driven.

Identify your launch criteria

This is the most important tool in this stage. Launch criteria are specific, measurable conditions that need to be met before you make your move.

Blake's framework: What needs to be true before you launch?

Financial criteria examples:

- 6 months emergency fund saved
- $X in side income established
- Debt paid down to $X
- Partner's income can cover expenses
- Severance package secured

Professional criteria examples:

- 3 paying clients lined up
- Job offer with $X salary
- Specific certification completed
- Portfolio with 5 strong case studies
- Clear path to health insurance

Personal criteria examples:

- Partner fully supportive of change
- Childcare situation stable
- Mental/physical health in good place
- Living situation secure
- Visa/legal status clear (for international moves)

Blake uses the "Pivot Hexagon" to evaluate readiness across six dimensions:

1. Values and vision alignment
2. Strengths and skills match
3. Financial foundation solid
4. Network and support system in place
5. Pilot data positive

6. Timing feels right

You don't need perfection across all six, but you need minimum thresholds met in each area.

Know when to hold versus fold

Blake addresses a critical question: How do you know when to persist through difficulty versus when to pivot away?

Hold when:

- The work aligns with your values and strengths
- Challenges are temporary or solvable
- You're making progress, even if slow
- Feedback is positive, trajectory is upward
- The difficulty is part of normal growth

Fold when:

- The work consistently drains you
- You're fighting against your natural strengths
- Multiple pilots confirm this isn't the right fit
- Market demand doesn't support this path
- Values misalignment becomes clear

From my recruiting experience: I see people stay in wrong-fit roles too long because they've invested so much. The sunk cost fallacy is real. Your past investment doesn't justify future misery.

I also see people quit too soon, before giving themselves enough data. The pilot phase should give you clear evidence either way.

Your gut has a brain

Blake cites research on intuition: your gut actually has neurons and makes decisions. But gut instinct works best when it's informed by data, not driven by fear or fantasy.

Good gut instinct:

- Informed by pilots and real experience
- Considers practical factors
- Balanced with rational analysis
- Feels like "yes, and it's scary" not "I hope this works out"

Bad gut instinct:

- Based on fantasy or avoidance
- Ignoring red flags
- Desperate or impulsive

- Feels like "I have to escape" rather than "I'm moving toward"

Separate decisions from difficult conversations

One reason people delay launch: they're dreading difficult conversations (telling their boss, disappointing family, explaining to friends).

Blake advises: Make the decision first, then plan the conversations.

Don't let fear of someone's reaction prevent you from making the right career move. Difficult conversations are temporary. Wrong career paths drain you for years.

Scripts for common difficult conversations:

Telling your boss: "I wanted to let you know I've accepted a position at [company]. My last day will be [date]. I'm grateful for the opportunities here and want to ensure a smooth transition."

Note: You don't owe them your life story or justifications. Be professional, brief, and focus on the transition.

Telling family who may not understand: "I know this seems different from what I've been doing, but I've spent [timeframe] researching and testing this direction. I'm confident in this move and excited about the opportunity."

Don't wait for perfect conditions

There's no perfect time to make a career change. There will always be uncertainty. The goal isn't to eliminate all risk—it's to reduce risk to an acceptable level based on your tolerance and situation.

Common "waiting for perfect" traps:

- Waiting until you feel completely ready (you won't)
- Waiting until you have every skill (you don't need them all)
- Waiting until the economy is better (timing is unpredictable)
- Waiting until your personal life is settled (it rarely is)

Launch when your criteria are met, even if you're still scared. Fear is normal. Paralysis is optional.

How do you know your launch worked?

Success metrics depend on your goals:

- Are you energized by the work?
- Can you sustain this financially?
- Are you learning and growing?
- Is there market demand for what you offer?

- Do you feel aligned with your values?

Some launches need 3 months to assess. Others need a year. Build in review points to evaluate and adjust.

The continuous pivot

Launch isn't the end. It's the beginning of the next cycle.

Careers are a series of pivots. You'll launch, lead for a while, then eventually need to plant again for your next move. The method is cyclical, not linear.

Stage 5: Lead 🎯

Purpose: Help others pivot and facilitate career development in your sphere of influence.

This final stage is often overlooked, but Blake argues it's essential both for others and for your own career growth.

Why leading matters

Once you've successfully pivoted, you have valuable knowledge:

- What worked in your transition
- What mistakes to avoid
- Which skills matter most
- How to navigate the specific challenges of your pivot

This knowledge is valuable to:

- Others considering a similar pivot
- Your company (improving internal mobility)
- Your industry (developing talent pipelines)
- Your own network (career karma)

How to use the Pivot Method within organizations

Framework for managers and leaders to facilitate career conversations:

1. Make career development ongoing, not annual

- Regular check-ins about growth and interests
- Ask about strengths and what's energizing them
- Discuss projects that align with their goals
- Create opportunities for pilots within the organization

2. Pilot creative internal mobility programs

- Job shadowing across departments

- Rotational programs
- Cross-functional project teams
- Internal mentorship matching
- Skill-sharing sessions

3. Help team members through their own Pivot stages

- Plant: Help them clarify values and vision
- Scan: Connect them with people and learning resources
- Pilot: Give them stretch assignments to test new directions
- Launch: Support internal transfers or thoughtful external moves
- Lead: Encourage them to mentor others

Career conversations that matter

Blake emphasizes: Your interest in someone's career development matters more than you think.

When managers actively support employee growth (even if it means the employee eventually moves to another team or company), they:

- Build loyalty and engagement short-term
- Create advocates and strong network long-term
- Develop reputation as a leader who cares
- Attract top talent who want to work with them

From my recruiting experience: The best managers I know lose people regularly, because they develop them so well that they get promoted or recruited away. But those managers never have trouble hiring, because everyone wants to work for someone who invests in their growth.

Your role in others' pivots

Even if you're not a manager, you can support pivots by:

- Sharing your story and lessons learned
- Making introductions to people in your network
- Reviewing resumes or providing feedback
- Offering to be a pilot client or test user
- Celebrating others' career wins

Career karma: The more you help others pivot successfully, the more support you'll have when you need your next pivot.

Common Pivot Mistakes (And How to Avoid Them)

Mistake #1: The big leap without pilots

What it looks like: Quitting your job to "find yourself" or "pursue your passion" without testing the waters first.

Why it fails: You're making a major life decision based on fantasy, not data. The reality of a career rarely matches the idea of it.

Solution: Always pilot first. Run experiments while employed. Gather real-world data before making irreversible decisions.

Mistake #2: Starting from scratch

What it looks like: "I want to completely change careers and do something totally different."

Why it fails: You're throwing away years of accumulated skills, relationships, and reputation. Starting from zero means competing with people who've spent years building what you're just beginning.

Solution: Find the "adjacent possible." What's one step away from what you're doing now? How can you leverage existing strengths in a new context?

Example from Blake: She didn't go from Google employee to professional chef. She went from Google training → Google career development → independent career consultant → broader business systems work. Each step built on the previous one.

My experience: The successful pivots I've hired include consultant → internal strategy, engineer → product management, teacher → corporate trainer, lawyer → compliance. These leverage transferable skills while changing context.

Mistake #3: Analysis paralysis

What it looks like: "I need to research more before I decide" (said for the 47th time).

Why it fails: You're using research as avoidance. At some point, more information doesn't help—you need experience.

Solution: Set decision deadlines. After X pilots or Y months of research, make a call with the information you have. Remember: you can always pivot again.

Practical approach: Blake recommends pilots over research. Twenty informational interviews teach you less than one freelance project actually doing the work.

Mistake #4: Ignoring your strengths

What it looks like: "I'm passionate about X, even though I'm not particularly good at it and it drains me."

Why it fails: Passion without skill equals hobby, not career. You'll struggle to compete and eventually burn out.

Solution: "Fuel your engine" first. Identify what you're naturally good at, what energizes you, where you excel with minimal effort. Find passion within your strengths, not despite them.

My recruiting reality: I see candidates pivot to fields they romanticize (often: product management, UX design, consulting, entrepreneurship). The ones who succeed have evidence of relevant strengths. The ones who fail are chasing an idea.

Mistake #5: No financial runway

What it looks like: "I'll figure out money later" or "I'll make it work somehow."

Why it fails: Desperation kills decision-making. You'll take the first offer out of panic, not alignment.

Solution: Fund your runway before you plant. Build savings, create side income, reduce expenses. Move from a position of security, not scarcity.

Non-negotiable minimum: 3-6 months expenses saved before any major launch. Ideally more if you're supporting others or entering a lower-paying field initially.

Why this matters in negotiations: When I'm hiring, I can tell when a candidate needs the job versus wants it. Desperation is obvious in how quickly they accept offers, how little they negotiate, how they frame questions. Runway gives you negotiating power.

Mistake #6: Skipping the network building

What it looks like: Applying to 100 jobs online without talking to a single person in the target field.

Why it fails: Most jobs (70-80%) are filled through networks. Your resume goes into a black hole when you have no internal champion.

Solution: "Bolster your bench" in the Scan phase. Build relationships before you need them. Give value before asking for favors.

My recruiting process: At Uber, my first step when opening a role is asking: "Who do we know?" If someone on the team vouches for a candidate, they jump to the front of the line. If they're a cold applicant with no connection, they need to be exceptional to get noticed.

Mistake #7: Not running enough pilots

What it looks like: Running one small experiment, having it not work perfectly, and giving up.

Why it fails: First pilots rarely succeed. You need quantity to gather enough data.

Solution: Aim for quantity over quality in the pilot phase. Run 5-10 small experiments, not one perfect test.

Example: If you're testing freelance writing, don't pitch one article and quit. Pitch 20, complete 5, join 2 communities, interview 3 writers. Aggregate data before making conclusions.

Understanding When to Pivot vs. When to Process

A pivot is proactive choice

Blake defines pivots as changes you make of your own volition when you're ready for increased challenge and impact. Key characteristics:

- You choose the timing (within reason)
- You plan the transition
- You maintain some control over the process
- You're moving toward something, not just away from something

Signs it's time to pivot:

- You've plateaued in your current role
- You're consistently bored or under-challenged
- Your values no longer align with your work
- You see limited growth opportunities ahead
- You daydream about other careers regularly
- Sunday nights fill you with dread

A crisis requires different support

Examples of crises (not pivots):

- Death of a loved one
- Serious illness or injury
- Unexpected job loss or firing
- Divorce or major relationship trauma
- Financial catastrophe
- Mental health emergency

Crises typically require more processing than planning, though not everyone will have the luxury to do those two things in sequence.

When you're in crisis:

- Give yourself space to grieve and heal
- Seek therapy or spiritual guidance if needed
- Focus on getting through each day
- Delay major career decisions if possible
- Rebuild emotional foundation before planning pivots

The gray area: Wake-up calls

Sometimes crises catalyze pivots. A health scare might make you reconsider your 80-hour work weeks. A layoff might push you toward the career change you'd been avoiding.

Blake acknowledges: "Painful experiences also serve as powerful wake-up calls, encouraging us to rebuild in an even more authentic direction."

The difference is timing: process the crisis first, then plan the pivot. Trying to do both simultaneously often leads to reactive decisions you later regret.

The Pivot Mindset: Reframing Career Change

Blake's framework requires a fundamental shift in how we think about career transitions.

Old career model vs. new career model

Old model (Career as Ladder):

- Linear progression up one ladder
- 40 years at one company
- Clear, predictable path
- Retirement with pension
- Job security as goal

New model (Career as Smartphone):

- Modular, customizable paths
- Average tenure: 4-5 years per job
- Dynamic, adaptive careers
- Multiple industries/roles over lifetime
- Continuous learning and pivoting as normal

Careers are no longer straightforward, linear, and predictable like ladders. They are now much more modular, customizable, and dynamic, like smartphones.

Shifting from scarcity to abundance thinking

Scarcity mindset:

- "I need to find THE right career"
- "If I make the wrong move, I'm screwed"
- "There's only one path for me"
- "I have to know the whole plan before I start"

Pivot mindset (Blake's framework):

- "What's ONE next move I can test?"
- "How can I reduce risk while exploring?"
- "What am I learning from this experiment?"
- "What's working that I can double down on?"

You will never see the entire pivot path at the outset, nor would you want to. If the next steps were obvious and manageable with a simple spreadsheet, you would either already be taking them or you would be bored.

From passion to strengths

Old thinking: "Find your passion, then figure out how to monetize it."

Blake's approach: "Identify your strengths, find work that uses them, discover passion in excellence and impact."

She writes in the Plant stage: "Fuel your engine" comes before "Put a pin in it." Know what you're good at before deciding where to go.

Why this matters: Passion without skill leads to frustration and failure. Skills without passion lead to burnout. The sweet spot is finding passion within work that leverages your natural strengths.

From perfect planning to iterative experimentation

Old approach: Research → Plan completely → Execute perfectly → Hope it works

Pivot Method: Plant → Scan → Pilot → Review → Adjust → Pilot again → Launch when ready

Conclusion: Your Next Move

Career changes force growth. They push you to develop new skills, meet new people, challenge assumptions, and discover capabilities you didn't know you had.

The regret question

What will you regret more, trying and failing, or never trying?

In my experience, regret comes from inaction, not from well-planned attempts that don't work out. The people I meet at 50 who are still in careers they hate aren't there because they tried something and failed. They're there because they never tried.

Failed pivots teach you something. Avoided pivots just accumulate resentment.

Start where you are

You don't need to have everything figured out to start. You don't need perfect conditions. You don't need to know the entire path.

If you're employed and uncertain: Start with Plant. Clarify your compass and vision.

If you know where you want to go: Move to Scan. Build network, bridge skills gaps.

If you've done research: Run Pilots. Test your assumptions with real experiments.

If you've tested and validated: Check your Launch criteria. Are you ready to move?

If you've pivoted successfully: Lead. Help others through their transitions.

The only move that matters is your next one. Not the perfect career five years out. Your next step.

What's yours?

Additional Resources

Read the full book: *Pivot: The Only Move That Matters Is Your Next One* by Jenny Blake

Blake recommends these books for deeper learning:

- *The Lean Startup* by Eric Ries (on piloting and experimentation)
- *Designing Your Life* by Bill Burnett and Dave Evans (on career design)
- *StrengthsFinder 2.0* by Tom Rath (on identifying strengths)
- *The Coaching Habit* by Michael Bungay Stanier (on facilitating career conversations)

My free resources for your pivot:

- Resume Checklist: What I check in the first 6 seconds
- Interview Preparation Sheet: My proven framework for interview success
- Offer Decision Scorecard: Evaluate job offers objectively
- Salary Calculator: Know your market value before negotiating

Quick Reference: The Pivot Method

Stage 1: Plant 🌱

Set your foundation

- **Calibrate compass:** Define values, happiness formula, non-negotiables
- **Put a pin in it:** Vision for 1 year from now (don't worry about how)
- **Fuel your engine:** Identify strengths, what's working, where you excel

- **Fund your runway:** Build 3-6 months savings, create side income

Key output: Clear direction and financial foundation

Stage 2: Scan 🔍

Gather intelligence

- **Bolster your bench:** Expand network, find advisors, practice career karma
- **Bridge the gaps:** Assess skills needed, create learning plan, focus on critical gaps
- **Make yourself discoverable:** Define unique value, build visibility, let people know you're exploring

Key output: Network built, skills identified, market awareness

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Stage 3: Pilot 🧪

Test before committing

- **Run small experiments:** Low risk, low cost tests that give real data
- **Quantity over quality:** Run 5-10 pilots, not 1 perfect test
- **Pause and review:** What worked? What didn't? What's next?

Key questions: Does this energize or drain you? Can you do the work? Is there market demand?

Key output: Evidence-based understanding of new direction

Stage 4: Launch 🚀

Make the move

- **Define criteria:** What must be true before you launch? (financial, professional, personal)
- **Build first, courage second:** Gather evidence and runway before leaping
- **Know when to fold:** If pilots consistently fail, pivot direction
- **Separate decisions from conversations:** Decide first, then handle difficult talks

Key output: Successful transition to new role/career

Stage 5: Lead 🎯

Help others pivot

- **Share your story:** Teach what you learned
- **Facilitate career conversations:** If you're a manager, support team growth
- **Practice career karma:** Give introductions, feedback, support
- **Pilot internal mobility:** Create opportunities for others to test new directions

Key output: Stronger network and leadership reputation

This guide is based on Jenny Blake's book "Pivot: The Only Move That Matters Is Your Next One." All framework concepts, and core methodology credit goes to Jenny Blake.